

55 Naomi

The widow who went out full, came home empty, and lived to hold her grandson in her arms.

Naomi of Bethlehem left home in a famine with her husband Elimelech and their two sons. In Moab her husband died, her sons married Moabite women, and then both sons died too. Naomi came home a grieving widow and asked to be called Mara, "bitter." Yet her daughter-in-law Ruth refused to leave her. As Ruth gleaned in Boaz's fields, Naomi saw God's kindness again and guided Ruth toward marriage with this kinsman. The book ends with Naomi holding Obed, the grandfather of King David.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew <i>Naomi</i> , "pleasant"; later <i>Mara</i> , "bitter" (Ruth 1:20)
Family	Wife of Elimelech; mother of Mahlon and Chilion (Ruth 1:2)
When	"When the judges ruled" (Ruth 1:1); no firm date
Key places	Bethlehem-judah, the country of Moab
Key people	Ruth, Orpah, Boaz, the women of Bethlehem
Grandson	Obed, grandfather of David (Ruth 4:16–17)
Main passages	Ruth 1–4
New Testament	Not named

"And the women said unto Naomi, Blessed be the LORD, which hath not left thee this day without a kinsman, that his name may be famous in Israel."

Ruth 4:14, KJV

The life of Naomi

No calendar date. Boaz as David's great-grandfather may point to the later judges, though the list may skip generations.

In a famine	● Leaves Bethlehem In a famine Elimelech takes Naomi and their sons Mahlon and Chilion from Bethlehem-judah to live in Moab. <i>Ruth 1:1-2</i>
About ten years in Moab	● Loses her family Elimelech dies. The sons marry Orpah and Ruth, and after about ten years both sons die. <i>Ruth 1:3-5</i>
On the road	● Turns for home Hearing that the LORD has given his people bread, she sets out for Judah. Orpah goes back, but Ruth clings to her. <i>Ruth 1:6-18</i>
Barley harvest	● Asks to be called Mara All Bethlehem is stirred. She tells the women she went out full, and the LORD has brought her home empty. <i>Ruth 1:19-22</i>
That evening	● Sees God's kindness Ruth comes home from Boaz's field with an ephah of barley. Naomi blesses the LORD, who "hath not left off his kindness," and explains that Boaz is a near kinsman. <i>Ruth 2:17-23</i>
End of harvest	● Plans for Ruth's rest Naomi sends Ruth to the threshing floor to ask Boaz, their kinsman, to take her under his care. <i>Ruth 3:1-5, 16-18</i>
Later	● Holds her grandson Boaz redeems Elimelech's land and marries Ruth. When Obed is born, Naomi lays the child in her bosom and becomes his nurse. <i>Ruth 4:9-17</i>

Key activities

Ruth 1:1 says "Bethlehem-judah" to set this Bethlehem apart from another in Zebulun (Joshua 19:15). Some readers see the move to Moab as a lapse of faith. The book itself does not judge it.

-
- 1 Moved her family to survive.** She went with Elimelech to Moab when famine struck. *Ruth 1:1-2*
 - 2 Blessed her daughters-in-law.** She prayed that the LORD would deal kindly with them and give them rest in new homes. *Ruth 1:8-9*
 - 3 Spoke her grief honestly.** She said "the hand of the LORD is gone out against me," and asked to be called Mara. *Ruth 1:13, 20-21*
 - 4 Came home.** She returned to Bethlehem because the LORD had visited his people with bread. *Ruth 1:6, 22*
 - 5 Recognized God's hand.** When she heard of Boaz, she praised the LORD's kindness "to the living and to the dead." *Ruth 2:19-20*
 - 6 Sought Ruth's future.** She planned for Ruth to find rest and a home with Boaz. *Ruth 3:1-4*
 - 7 Waited wisely.** "Sit still, my daughter, until thou know how the matter will fall." *Ruth 3:18*
 - 8 Nursed Obed.** She cared for Ruth's son, and the neighbor women said, "There is a son born to Naomi." *Ruth 4:16-17*
-

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Naomi.

Old Testament

Ruth 1–4	Naomi appears throughout the book.
Echoes	Job also refused to hide his pain: "I will complain in the bitterness of my soul" (Job 7:11). "Weeping may endure for a night, but joy cometh in the morning" (Psalm 30:5).

New Testament

Echoes	Her grandson Obed appears in Jesus' family line (Matthew 1:5; Luke 3:32). Jesus meets a grieving widow at Nain and gives her son back to her (Luke 7:11–15). "All things work together for good to them that love God" (Romans 8:28).
--------	---

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Naomi say to the women of Bethlehem when she came home (Ruth 1:20–21)?
2. *Understand:* Naomi said God had afflicted her, yet she still prayed for and blessed others. What does that show about honest faith?
3. *Apply:* Naomi said she came home "empty," but Ruth was beside her. Who has God placed beside you in a hard season?
4. *Apply:* Naomi helped plan Ruth's future. Whom could you encourage or help toward a good future this week?

Group notes